



FAMILY COURT DATA REPORT · STATE SERIES · NO. 48

WASHINGTON

WHAT FAMILIES ARE REPORTING.

Pulled from the Family Rights Registry — the first cross-state dataset on what pro se parents are actually experiencing inside Washington's family courts and child-welfare system.

49

WASHINGTON FAMILIES ON RECORD ·
63 CHILDREN IMPACTED · 12 MONTHS
MEDIAN MONTHS LOST OF PARENTING
TIME

REPORT GENERATED
APRIL 26, 2026

COUNTIES REPRESENTED
16 OF 39

COMPILED BY
MEG · STANDWITHMEG.COM

THE HEADLINE NUMBERS

WASHINGTON AT A GLANCE.

Across 49 Washington families reporting through the Family Rights Registry, the patterns are consistent: long durations in court, serious financial loss, and a disproportionate number of parents going unrepresented because they ran out of money fighting.

CHILDREN IMPACTED 63 49 of 49 families reported child counts	MEDIAN ATTORNEY FEES \$47,500 per reporting family	MEDIAN MONTHS LOST 12 of parenting time	WENT PRO SE 57.1% 42.9% after running out of money
SUBMISSIONS 49	AVG CHILDREN / FAMILY 1.3	FAMILIES REPORTING CHILDREN 49 of 49	COUNTIES REPRESENTED 16

WHY THIS REPORT EXISTS.

On January 29, 2024, I lost custody of all five of my children.

- NO TRIAL.
- NO QUESTIONING.
- NO SUBSTANTIATED ABUSE.

It took only a signature on an ex parte emergency order to erase a mother. I refused to disappear. I fought back, and built the Family Rights Registry so Washington families — and families in every state — would stop being invisible to the data. This report is their record.

— MEG · [STANDWITHMEG.COM](https://standwithmeg.com)

02

THE COST OF WASHINGTON FAMILY COURT

Legal fees are the largest reported expense, but they are not the only one. Lost wages, evaluation costs, and reunification services compound the financial loss — pushing most families toward pro se representation once their savings run out.

EXPENSE CATEGORY	RESPONSES	MEDIAN	MEAN	TOTAL REPORTED
Attorney Fees	28	\$47,500	\$89,100	\$2,494,800
Lost Wages	19	\$40,000	\$108,132	\$2,054,500
Other Court Fees	18	\$750	\$1,600	\$28,800
Therapy / Evaluations	23	\$3,500	\$4,487	\$103,200
Reunification Services	15	\$500	\$6,267	\$94,010
GAL Fees	22	\$3,000	\$8,970	\$197,350
Asset Loss ¹	22	\$82,500	—	—
Estimated Median Family Impact	—	\$177,750	—	—

Median vs. mean: Median is the middle reported amount, so it better reflects the typical reporting family when a few very large expenses appear. Mean is the average across reporting families and can be pulled higher by outliers.

1. On asset loss: One respondent reported an extreme outlier that skews the mean beyond usefulness. We report the median (\$82,500) and suppress the mean and total, pending data-quality review. Lost Wages also contains wide variance; median is the honest headline.

LOST PARENTING TIME · MONTHS

Median months lost		12	1 yr
Mean months lost		38	3.2 yrs
Total across all families		1,097	91.4 yrs

03 WHO IS REPORTING · WASHINGTON

Most families documenting in Washington are currently active in, or recently closed out of, long-running cases. Nearly half have lost all contact with their children.

CASE STATUS · SYSTEM AFFECTED

CASE STATUS

Active case: stuck or delayed		18	37%
Not provided		16	33%
Case closed: more than 2 years ago		10	20%
Case closed: within last 2 years		4	8%
I was a Child of Family Court or CPS		1	2%

SYSTEM AFFECTED

Both Family Court and CPS		19	39%
Family Court Only		16	33%
Unknown		9	18%
CPS (Child Protective Services) Only		5	10%

DURATION · CUSTODY OUTCOMES

TIME IN SYSTEM

1 – 3 years		13	27%
5 – 10 years		10	20%
3 – 5 years		6	12%
5+ years		6	12%
6 months – 1 year		5	10%

CUSTODY STATUS

No Contact / Total Loss of Access		20	41%
Visitation Only		12	24%
Full Custody		7	14%
Adopted Out (Rights Terminated)		3	6%
Children in Foster Care		3	6%

GEOGRAPHY · ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

TOP COUNTIES

King		6	12%
Pierce		5	10%
Clark		3	6%
Spokane		3	6%
Clallam		2	4%
Skagit		2	4%

TOP ALLEGATIONS REPORTED

Family Court False Accusations (Domestic Violence/Abuse/Alienation)		16	33%
High Conflict Divorce		7	14%
False Accusations CPS (Non-Medical) (Vengeful ex-partner, malicious report)		6	12%
Other: (Short answer)		4	8%
Family Court		4	8%

05 PARENT VOICES — WASHINGTON

Quotes appear as submitted. Long submissions are trimmed with [...] to fit the page; the full unedited quote is available in the online version of this report.



The system has failed my children, took them from my care after 7 years of raising them since birth, put them in the home where they have been sexually assaulted, physically abused, and severely neglected. Their court restrained me from all contact with my children including [...]

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

ON THE REPORTED ALLEGATIONS

My children hate me. They were told that I abused them in many ways. I have been denied reunification.

— WASHINGTON PARENT · JENNIFER

MORE VOICES FROM WASHINGTON

Cuz Harmon my daughter mentally emotional physical and bent me over and rape me metaphorically speaking they didn't give me prison lube use that quote and that's how I feel about it too I'll call him B.K.O.A human traffickers extraordinaires ask Shelton Washington's dcyf I'll [...]

— JESSE

depleted my resources that could have gone to kids, failed to hold my abuser accountable and rewarded him instead—even with findings of perjury and abuse on record: emotional trauma defending against false allegations against abuser and GAL in corroboration with psych evaluator.

— CHRISTINA

i have lost all access to my children who are currently 9 and 7. they were taken from my custody by their abusive father who has used money to buy his way out of being exposed for the sexual abuse he has committed upon my children. i spoke out and tried to receive help from [...]

— LEANA

The family court system very clearly took my ex abusers side. I never stood a chance. The GAL changed her recommendation the day before trial. Which is against the law. She changed her recommendation to her other parent having full custody even though he had just spent 3 years [...]

— CHEYANNE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



The system took my grandson and he was abused in foster care.

— STACIE

This has destroyed the relationship between mother and child with all four of my daughters. My voice has been silenced, my kids' best interests have been ignored and this situation has even manifested into serious health concerns that I never dealt with prior.

— JESSIKAH

Purgery took my kids 12 years ago left us with 4 nights a month. Much more serious false allegations 6 years ago left us completely alienated, a direct result of a corrupt system and my lack of money.

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Has killed my 4 year old son Kannin born to Canadian mom and dad he was medically kidnapped by Seattle childrens and DCYF I have not seen my daughter in 6 years all my kids were ordered home

— ASHLEY

They're completely destroyed decimated my family my children are shells of who they were and who they should be and separated from my husband or father lost every possession we own and now I'm dying of a heart failure and a broken heart's disease

— MISTY

The system has vilified me and convinced everyone i am crazy even though I have 5 evaluations that's say I am not. It has traumatized me and my children.

— ANGILIA

Destroyed me and my family Larry C Baker and Egypt Baker and unique Baker

— LARRY

My family is incomplete, separated, and I live a bittersweet nightmare called my life... With living grief and trauma to us all.

— MICHELLE

My ex abandoned me my entire pregnancy begged me, then took me to court said I withheld our daughter and told them I was crazy. The judge believed majority of the lies and labeled me as high conflict and placed a 191 in WA on me, CPS found abuse in his home and the judge said I [...]

— ANDREA

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



This system is dragging out the abuse I spent years trying to leave while attorneys bankrupt me, and the ex lives his delusional world subjecting me to further abuse every single day.

— MEGAN

“This system shattered my family — it stole time with my children that none of us can ever get back, and it broke my faith in the Constitution and in the leaders who are supposed to protect families, not profit from their pain.”

— MATTHEW

he actions of DCYF have subjected our family to a "pervasive and documented pattern of professional misconduct," including the traumatic midnight removal of our children and systemic negligence that resulted in "severe physical, emotional, and financial harm". This campaign of [...]

— JOSEPH

Broke us and stole our peace for over a decade and still ongoing.

— CHRIS

After the divorce, I was terrorized into being fired from her dad's business (Paradise Fibers), so she could work there again. I am the alienated parent, not her. She a narcissist and chronic covert abuser

— JASON

The CORRUPT LAKEWOOD DCYF HAS USED THEIR DEGREES AND CERTIFICATIONS TO DESTROY ME AND MY DAUGHTERS LIFE, OUR PEACE OF MIND, OUR HEARTS AND OUR HOPE FOR A BETTER TOMORROW.

— BRITTNEY

It put my children in physical harm and emotional distress , it has taken a good mother who is the only safe place away from my children . They criminally charged me for protecting my babies which now is held against me on the family side

— RIKKI

Made my son be a pawn in a war he never wanted to be

— HALLEY

Marin County, CA., King County, WA., & Carter County, TN. I was a victim and ultimate loser to Family Court in all 3 jurisdictions. Relationships with children was established only after they reached adulthood. They all feel like they lost out due to the actions taken.

— TERRANCE

05 PARENT VOICES, CONTINUED



They have done everything they can to isolate my family from each other and sold my babies never giving any options to reunite us only too keep us. All jumping through hoops archive no progress

— ALICIA

Family Court is the Wild West of the system. Lawlessly ripping families apart for financial gain with a complete disregard for the humans effected!

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

Ruined the family and zero accountability for all the inequities with the “no fault” divorce clause

— ANONYMOUS PARENT

As a egg being my family . To grow the purpose of egg is to be taken care of but no we were brutally crushed in the hands that knew better . Hands being the system. We stand no chance . For all eggs 讀諸 get crushed .

— AMY

I was cheated of 50/50 parenting time with my daughters. My daughters love me and I am a totally fit dad , yet I was still denied custody of my children. My daughters wanted 50/50 just like I did. The courts ignore the rule of clear and convincing evidence. They're just making [...]

— GERARDO

My son had lived almost exclusively with me his whole life prior to the current case. This completely disrupted life as he knew it and took away all normalcy and comfort. He has been sick and injured more this year than he has the whole rest of his life combined. He now [...]

— MIKAYLA

30 Washington parents submitted ranked quotes. 30 appear in this report; the remainder are available at standwithmeg.com/wa.

06 HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

WHAT THIS IS

The Family Rights Registry is a national, parent-reported data collection run by Stand With Meg. Every figure in this Washington report comes from Washington respondents who voluntarily submitted survey entries about their experience inside family court and/or CPS.

This report is built to help families, advocates, reporters, and legislators see the patterns emerging in Washington — not to replace formal research, and not to name individual judges or counties as responsible parties.

WHAT IT ISN'T

This is not a representative sample. Respondents self-select. The 49 Washington families reporting here are not the universe of Washington families in court — they are the families who found the survey, trusted it enough to submit, and told us what happened to them.

Financial figures are self-reported. We flag outliers and report medians when means are distorted (see page 3, note 1). Quotes are minimally edited.

METHODOLOGY · FAMILY RIGHTS REGISTRY

Data in this report was collected April 2024 – April 2026 through standwithmeg.com/family-rights-survey. Submissions are timestamped. Duplicate-submission heuristics use normalized email + location, with direct survey rows preferred over legacy rows and the newest row retained within each source. Categorical responses from multi-select and short-answer fields are normalized monthly.

When a respondent's financial entry differs from the population by more than three standard deviations, the mean is suppressed and only the median is reported. Lost-wage, attorney-fee, and asset-loss entries are self-reported and not corroborated against tax records or court filings.

Geographic reporting uses the county field as submitted, with light normalization (e.g. "Butte silverbow" → "Butte-Silver Bow"). Quotes carry one of three public permission states: *Anonymous*, *First-name only*, or *Full attribution with consent to public use*. Court actor names appear only after 5 independent families name the same actor.

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ABOUT THIS REPORT

This report is based on self-reported survey submissions collected by Stand With Meg. Counts and categories reflect responses available at the time this packet was generated.

This report is for informational and advocacy use only, not legal advice or an official government record.

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